

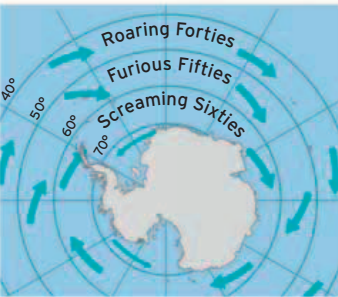
SNOW ALGAE

Some species of single-celled algae can survive in snow and ice. Some produce red pigments that mask green chlorophyll and resist frost and deadly ultraviolet rays that penetrate snow. Barely visible in winter, algae rise to the surface in summer, creating algal blooms that color whole snowbanks red, pink, orange, green, or gray.

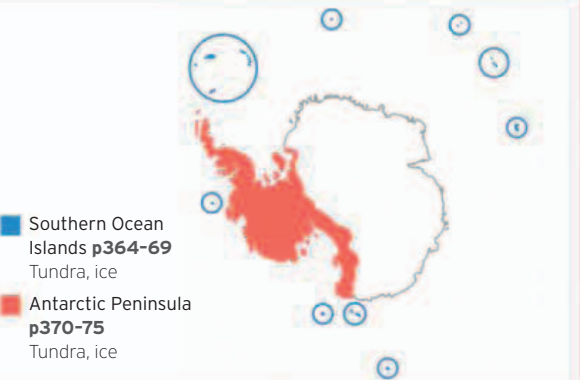


ROARING WINDS

Westerly winds sweep unimpeded around the Southern Ocean. The Roaring Forties is the area between 40° and 50° latitude south. Now, due to a shift in weather patterns caused by climate change, these winds appear to be moving south, becoming stronger, and merging with the Furious Fifties.



FEATURED ECOREGIONS



ANTARCTIC PLANTS



The coastal fringe of the peninsula is the only area free of permanent ice. Mosses and lichens dominate the tundra vegetation. Swards of Antarctic hair grass and cushions of Antarctic pearlwort are the only flowering plants.



CIRCULAR OCEAN MOVEMENT

The winds around Antarctica drive the Antarctic Circumpolar Current, sealing off the Southern Ocean and creating the world's roughest seas.

ROSS SEA AND ICE SHELF

The vast Ross Ice Shelf shelters an abundance of invertebrate life below. Winds driving away sea-ice next to the ice shelf can create ice-free areas of water called polynyas. The summer sun brings forth blooms of phytoplankton and the Ross Sea bursts into life, supporting whales, seals, penguins, petrels, fish, and more than 1,000 species of invertebrate.

